However, to make matters worse, another border death involving 54-year-old West German, Guenter Zoellner, caused widespread fury. Zoellner had died when walking from a railway carriage to a border post to be interrogated. It transpired that GDR guards had hauled him off the train after discovering two pounds of ham in his suitcase that was not entered in his customs declaration. From then on, a chorus of Western travellers piped-up with tales of aggressive treatment by East German border authorities, who enjoyed wide latitude to examine travellers. The fallout even reached the pages of Pravda in Moscow, which asserted: 'the West Berlin public is following with increasing alarm the inflammatory propaganda campaign launched by extreme right-wing West German and West Berlin circles against the GDR'.6

Given the unfolding of events, Honecker cancelled a trip to West Germany planned for late 1983. However, amid this strained time, he secured a financial loan of DM1billion from a consortium of West German banks in a deal engineered by Bavaria's state prime minister, Franz Josef Strauss (Alexander Schalck-Golodkowski played the role of intermediary and applied a deft negotiating touch from a position of comparative weakness).

In June, the GDR gave Bonn securities for the full amount of the loan along with promises to ease currency exchange requirements for Westerners visiting East Germany and, for the first time, the pledge that GDR citizens would have the legal right to apply for permission to emigrate to join close family members in the West. The expectation thus raised was that the GDR would, sooner or later, embark on border relaxations. In an extraordinary diplomatic enterprise, Strauss was received on a private visit with his wife and son at Honecker's hunting lodge, where they were left impressed by his agility and mental responsiveness. 'It's a shame that he's a communist,' Strauss's wife slyly remarked. 'Even after his first few sentences, I was surprised not to be facing the wooden functionary I had seen on TV. He never stepped out of his role, but the image of mask-like rigidity that one creates of him is wrong.'7 Moreover, Strauss thought the First Secretary spoke very fluently and thoughtfully: